

# The Sahara



THE SHIFTING SANDS of the Sahara Desert stretch across 3,475,000 sq miles (9,000,000 sq km) of northern Africa, an area almost as big as the United States. The Sahara is the largest desert in the world. In the baking heat of the day,

the temperature soars to over 122°F (50°C) in the shade. But at night it is bitterly cold. In some parts of the desert there may be no rain at all for several years.

The animals that live in the Sahara have adapted to this harsh environment in a variety of ways. Many small animals hide in burrows during the day and come out only at dawn and dusk, when it is cooler. Most desert animals can go for long periods without water. Some never drink—they get all the moisture they need from the plants and insects they eat.



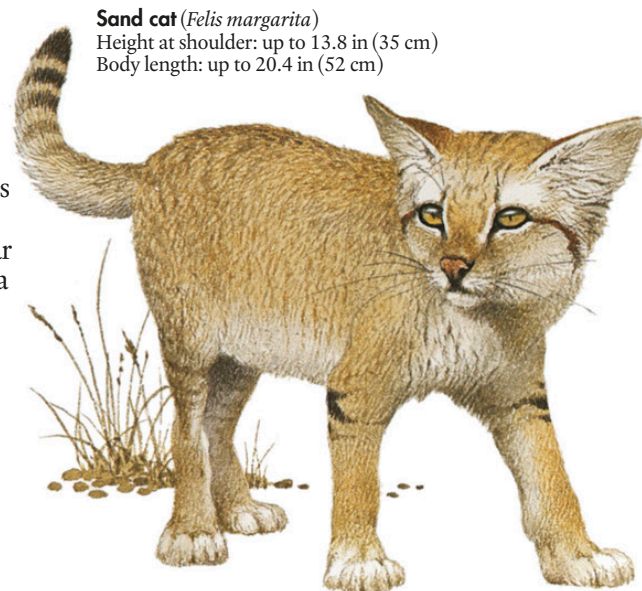
**Desert hedgehog**  
(*Paraechinus aethiopicus*)  
Length: up to 9.5 in (24 cm)



**Sandfish**  
(*Scincus scincus*)  
Length including tail: up to 8 in (20 cm)

## Sand swimmer

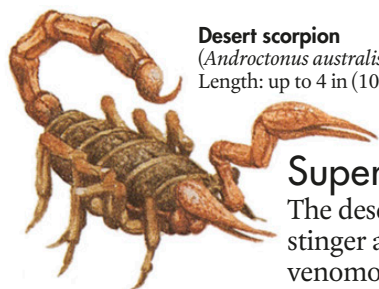
The sandfish gets its name from the way it “swims” through sand. The lizard’s streamlined shape helps it dive into the sand, wriggling from side to side. This behavior helps it avoid the Sun’s burning heat.



**Sand cat** (*Felis margarita*)  
Height at shoulder: up to 13.8 in (35 cm)  
Body length: up to 20.4 in (52 cm)

## Prickly hunter

The desert hedgehog spends the day in a burrow and hunts at night. Its long legs lift its body above the hot sand. It often eats scorpions, biting off the stinger first.



**Desert scorpion**  
(*Androctonus australis*)  
Length: up to 4 in (10 cm)

## Super sting

The desert scorpion defends itself with the stinger at the end of its tail. The sting is as venomous as a cobra bite and can kill a much larger animal, such as a dog, in only seven minutes.

## Big ears

The fennec fox has huge ears that can be up to 6 in (15 cm) long. The large, thin surface of its ears allows heat to escape from its body and helps keep it cool. When it hunts, the fox can hear its prey moving around.



**Fennec fox** (*Vulpes zerda*)  
Body length: up to 15.5 in (39.5 cm)  
Tail: up to 9.8 in (25 cm)

## Champion jumper

The jerboa is like a tiny kangaroo. It can jump up to 8 ft (2.5 m) in one bound to escape from enemies. Its strong back legs are four times as long as its front legs. Its long tail helps the jerboa balance when it jumps.



**Lesser Egyptian jerboa** (*Jaculus jaculus*)  
Body length: up to 5 in (13 cm)  
Tail: up to 7.7 in (19.7 cm)

